

History of English Literature - Important MCQs (Part 35)

Page 172 - Gray and Burns

Q1. Which poem is described as having features making it historically very important, including a churchyard scene and twilight atmosphere?

- A. The Deserted Village
- B. The Task
- C. Elegy written in a Country Churchyard
- D. The Cotter's Saturday Night

Answer: C

Q2. What Augustan poetic trick does Gray continue to use in the 'Elegy'?

- A. Free verse
- B. Heroic couplets exclusively
- C. Personification and capital letters
- D. Satirical allegories

Answer: C

Q3. Which of the following is one of Gray's two great odes?

- A. The Task
- B. The Bard
- C. The Fatal Sisters
- D. Ode to Duty

Answer: B

Q4. Gray's great odes are filled with the new conception of the poet as:

- A. An accomplished artist or 'wit'
- B. An inspired singer or 'enthusiast'
- C. A political commentator
- D. A logical philosopher

Answer: B

Q5. Which of Gray's short poems takes its place in the history of the revival of the romantic past?

- A. The Progress of Poesy

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- B. The Fatal Sisters
- C. Ode to Spring
- D. The Alliance of Education and Government

Answer: B

Q6. Robert Burns was a poet primarily known for being a:

- A. Wealthy aristocrat
- B. London city merchant
- C. Scottish peasant
- D. Welsh clergyman

Answer: C

Q7. In Gray's 'Elegy', the contrast is drawn between the peasants' simple life and what?

- A. The madding crowd's ignoble strife
- B. The corrupt court's vanity
- C. The philosopher's solitude
- D. The soldier's tragic glory

Answer: A

Q8. What was the ultimate basis of Robert Burns's strength as a poet?

- A. Absolute sincerity to himself and his surroundings
- B. His imitation of Alexander Pope
- C. His mastery of classical Latin poetry
- D. His wealthy patrons

Answer: A

Q9. Gray's 'Elegy' reaches out to include humble aspects of life under the influence of the spreading:

- A. Autocratic spirit
- B. Democratic spirit
- C. Religious revival
- D. Industrial revolution

Answer: B

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Q10. How did Gray's poetic career develop over time?

- A. From romanticism to Augustan verse
- B. He wrote only in one style his whole life
- C. From versified pamphlets in Pope's manner to fundamentally romantic experiments
- D. From dramatic plays to pastoral comedies

Answer: C

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Page 173 - Robert Burns and William Cowper

Q1. Was Robert Burns considered an unlettered plowman?

- A. Yes, he could barely read or write
- B. No, he read widely and critically
- C. Yes, he relied entirely on oral tradition
- D. No, he was a university professor

Answer: B

Q2. What is Robert Burns's most ambitious poem?

- A. The Task
- B. Elegy written in a Country Churchyard
- C. The Cotter's Saturday Night
- D. The Bard

Answer: C

Q3. In what stanza is 'The Cotter's Saturday Night' written?

- A. Heroic Couplet
- B. Blank Verse
- C. Spenserian Stanza
- D. Terza Rima

Answer: C

Q4. What were the chief literary influences behind Burns's own work?

- A. Standard English literature
- B. Classical Greek drama
- C. Vernacular poetry like songs and ballads of Scottish peasant folk
- D. French romantic novels

Answer: C

Q5. To which political spirit of his age was Burns keenly responsive?

- A. The Royalist spirit
- B. The Revolutionary spirit

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- C. The Imperialist spirit
- D. The Reactionary spirit

Answer: B

Q6. Who wrote the line: 'The rank is but the guinea's stamp / The man's the gowd for a' that'?

- A. Thomas Gray
- B. William Cowper
- C. Robert Burns
- D. Christopher Smart

Answer: C

Q7. What was William Cowper's temperament described as?

- A. Full-blooded and robust
- B. Delicate, sensitive, morbid
- C. Joyful and highly sociable
- D. Apathetic and stoic

Answer: B

Q8. Why did William Cowper begin to write poetry late in life?

- A. To make money for his debts
- B. To win literary fame
- C. As a means of keeping his mind from preying upon itself
- D. To challenge Robert Burns's popularity

Answer: C

Q9. In his satires, which conventional model does Cowper follow?

- A. Dryden
- B. Spenser
- C. Milton
- D. Pope

Answer: D

Q10. What is William Cowper's principal poem?

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- A. The Task
- B. The Seasons
- C. The Cotter's Saturday Night
- D. Grongar Hill

Answer: A

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Page 174 - William Cowper's Poetry

Q1. 'The Task' is often considered the poetic masterpiece of later 18th century:

- A. Rationalism
- B. Evangelicalism
- C. Catholicism
- D. Romanticism

Answer: B

Q2. What verse form is 'The Task' written in?

- A. Blank verse
- B. Heroic couplet
- C. Spenserian stanza
- D. Ballad meter

Answer: A

Q3. How is the structure of 'The Task' described?

- A. Tightly organized with a clear narrative
- B. Extremely discursive, rambling, and wanting in structural backbone
- C. Composed of strict five-act dramatic sections
- D. Formatted as an epistolary novel

Answer: B

Q4. Who wrote the line: 'God made the country and man made the town'?

- A. Robert Burns
- B. Thomas Gray
- C. William Cowper
- D. Alexander Pope

Answer: C

Q5. In his sympathetic treatment of nature and landscape, Cowper comes nearest of all 18th century poets to:

- A. John Keats

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- B. William Wordsworth
- C. Lord Byron
- D. Percy Bysshe Shelley

Answer: B

Q6. What does 'The Task' denounce as the symbol of tyranny and irresponsible authority?

- A. The British Monarchy
- B. The Bastille
- C. The Church of England
- D. The Tower of London

Answer: B

Q7. When was the passage attacking the Bastille published in 'The Task'?

- A. 1775
- B. 1785
- C. 1789
- D. 1793

Answer: B

Q8. In a rough way, due to indications of social unrest, Cowper's poetry points forward to which poet?

- A. Keats
- B. Shelley
- C. Byron
- D. Scott

Answer: C

Q9. When Cowper was born, who was at the height of his power?

- A. John Dryden
- B. Alexander Pope
- C. John Milton
- D. Samuel Johnson

Answer: B

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Q10. What did Cowper say was the real text of 'The Task'?

- A. Praise of retirement and of country life as favourable to religion and virtue
- B. The promotion of industrialization in cities
- C. The defense of classical literary rules
- D. A purely autobiographical confession

Answer: A

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Page 175 - Christopher Smart and the Age of Johnson

Q1. Where was Christopher Smart educated?

- A. Oxford
- B. Cambridge
- C. Edinburgh
- D. Dublin

Answer: B

Q2. Where did Christopher Smart spend a while towards the end of his life due to poverty?

- A. In exile in France
- B. In a debtors' prison
- C. On a wealthy patron's estate
- D. In the royal court

Answer: B

Q3. Which of Christopher Smart's poems is considered one of the greatest among English religious poems?

- A. Jubilate Agno
- B. Song to David
- C. The Task
- D. Night Thoughts

Answer: B

Q4. Robert Browning's poem 'Saul' owed much to which of Smart's works?

- A. Jubilate Agno
- B. The Hop-Garden
- C. Song to David
- D. A Song to David

Answer: C

Q5. What is the name of Smart's remarkable work that was left as a jumble of manuscript?

- A. Song to David
- B. Jubilate Agno

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C. The Seasons

D. The Task

Answer: B

Q6. Who is 'Jeoffrey' in Smart's 'Jubilate Agno'?

A. His son

B. His dog

C. His cat

D. His patron

Answer: C

Q7. In what year was Richardson's 'Pamela' published?

A. 1740

B. 1742

C. 1748

D. 1751

Answer: A

Q8. In what year was Fielding's 'Joseph Andrews' published?

A. 1740

B. 1742

C. 1748

D. 1749

Answer: B

Q9. Which famous poet died in 1744?

A. John Dryden

B. Alexander Pope

C. James Thomson

D. Samuel Johnson

Answer: B

Q10. In what year was Fielding's 'Tom Jones' published?

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A. 1748

B. 1749

C. 1751

D. 1754

Answer: B

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Page 176 - Chronology of the Age of Johnson

Q1. In what year was Johnson's Dictionary published?

- A. 1751
- B. 1755
- C. 1759
- D. 1765

Answer: B

Q2. Who wrote 'Essay on the Sublime and Beautiful' published in 1756?

- A. Samuel Johnson
- B. Edmund Burke
- C. David Hume
- D. Adam Smith

Answer: B

Q3. Which history book was published by David Hume between 1754 and 1761?

- A. History of Scotland
- B. History of England
- C. Decline and Fall of the Roman Empire
- D. History of Great Britain

Answer: B

Q4. In what year was Samuel Johnson's 'Rasselas' published?

- A. 1755
- B. 1759
- C. 1764
- D. 1765

Answer: B

Q5. Which famous English novelist, author of 'Pamela' and 'Clarissa', died in 1761?

- A. Henry Fielding
- B. Tobias Smollett

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C. Samuel Richardson

D. Laurence Sterne

Answer: C

Q6. When was Laurence Sterne's 'Tristram Shandy' published?

A. 1740-42

B. 1748-51

C. 1759-61

D. 1764-70

Answer: C

Q7. Which poet, famous for his 'Songs of Innocence', was born in 1757?

A. William Cowper

B. Robert Burns

C. William Blake

D. George Crabbe

Answer: C

Q8. In what year was Horace Walpole's 'The Castle of Otranto' published?

A. 1759

B. 1760

C. 1764

D. 1765

Answer: D

Q9. Which important ballad collection was published by Percy in 1765?

A. Lyrical Ballads

B. Reliques of Ancient English Poetry

C. Minstrelsy of the Scottish Border

D. Ossianic Poems

Answer: B

Q10. Between 1760 and 1763, James Macpherson published the poems of which supposedly ancient bard?

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- A. Rowley
- B. Ossian
- C. Taliesin
- D. Merlin

Answer: B